

Essential Skills Every Front-of-House Worker Needs

The complete skills guide for servers, hosts, bartenders, and bussers, from your first shift to shift lead

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- The 12 core front-of-house skills
- Steps of service and table maintenance standards
- Handling allergies, alcohol, and difficult guests
- Skills self-assessment and growth plan

04

Skill checklists, service standards, and a self-assessment to plan your growth

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CHAPTER 1

What Great Front-of-House Workers Have in Common

Front of house (FOH) is the part of the restaurant guests see: hosts, servers, bartenders, bussers, food runners, and managers. The kitchen makes the food, but FOH makes the experience.

The best FOH workers aren't just friendly. They're organized, calm under pressure, and always two steps ahead. Every one of those skills can be learned.

The 12 core skills

Skill	Why it matters
1. Hospitality mindset	Guests remember how you made them feel more than what they ate
2. Communication	Clear words with guests, kitchen, and team prevent mistakes
3. Menu knowledge	Confident recommendations increase sales and trust
4. Multitasking and prioritizing	Busy shifts require juggling many tables at once
5. Time management	Timing courses, checks, and side work keeps the room running
6. Memory and attention to detail	Orders, allergies, and preferences must be right
7. Teamwork	Restaurants run on people helping each other
8. Problem-solving	Things go wrong every shift; how you fix them matters
9. Staying calm under pressure	Stress spreads, and so does calm
10. Food safety and allergy awareness	Guest health depends on it
11. Responsible alcohol service	Protects guests, you, and the restaurant's license
12. POS and cash handling	Accuracy protects your money and your job

CHAPTER 2

The Hospitality Mindset

Service is doing your job. Hospitality is making people feel cared for while you do it.

Service vs. hospitality

Service	Hospitality
Bringing the food on time	Noticing a guest is cold and offering a table away from the door
Taking the order correctly	Remembering a regular's usual and asking about their kid's game
Answering questions	Offering a sample when a guest can't decide
Dropping the check	Thanking the guest by name and inviting them back

Habits of hospitality

- **Make eye contact and smile** at every guest you pass, not just the ones in your section.
- **Say yes when you can.** Look for ways to meet requests before saying no.
- **Own the guest's experience.** If you see a problem at any table, help or get help.
- **Stay genuine.** Guests can tell when you're following a script without meaning it.

CHAPTER 3

The Steps of Service

Most restaurants follow a version of these steps. Learn your restaurant's specific standards, but this framework works almost anywhere.

1. **Greet** within 60 seconds of seating. Introduce yourself and offer drinks.
2. **Deliver drinks** and take appetizer orders. Share specials.
3. **Take the order.** Repeat back tricky orders, and ask about allergies.
4. **Enter the order** into the POS right away, with accurate modifiers.
5. **Deliver food** with a description ("Here's your salmon with lemon butter"), and place plates in the right position.
6. **Check back** within two bites or two minutes.
7. **Maintain the table:** refills, clearing, fresh silverware.
8. **Offer dessert and after-dinner drinks.**
9. **Present the check** at the right time, and process payment promptly.
10. **Thank and farewell:** invite guests back.

Table maintenance standards

- Water glasses refilled before they're half empty
- Empty glasses and plates cleared promptly (once everyone at the table is finished)
- Used silverware replaced before the next course
- Crumbs and spills cleaned between courses
- Condiments and extra napkins brought before the guest needs to ask
- Table is never left without a check-in for too long

CHAPTER 4

Communication Skills

With guests

- **Speak clearly** and adjust your volume to the room.
- **Listen fully** before answering. Repeat back orders with modifications.
- **Use positive language:** say "What I can do is..." instead of "We can't."
- **Read body language:** crossed arms, looking around, or pushed-away plates all tell you something.

With the kitchen

- Enter orders accurately and completely. The kitchen can only make what's on the ticket.
- Use your restaurant's terms ("on the fly," "86'd," "all day," "behind") correctly.
- Communicate allergies clearly and directly, in person as well as in the system when that's your restaurant's policy.
- Be respectful, even when things are hectic. The kitchen is your partner.

With your team

- Call out "behind," "corner," and "hot" when moving through the restaurant.
- Tell teammates when you need help, and offer help when you see someone drowning.
- Hand off tables with clear notes: what's been ordered, what's pending, any special requests.

Common restaurant terms

Term	Meaning
86'd	Out of an item; it's no longer available
On the fly	Needed as fast as possible
All day	Total count of an item needed across all orders
In the weeds	Overwhelmed and behind
Behind / Corner / Hot	Safety call-outs to avoid collisions
Campers	Guests who stay long after finishing
Comp	An item given for free
Double / Clopen	Two shifts in one day / closing then opening the next morning
Expo	The person or station that checks and sends food out
Top	Number of guests at a table ("a four-top")

CHAPTER 5

Menu Knowledge and Selling

Know every item

- Main ingredients and preparation (fried, grilled, raw, etc.)
- Common allergens (see the table in the next chapter)
- Portion sizes and what's good to share
- What can and can't be modified
- Two or three descriptive words for every item

Know the drinks

- House cocktails and what's in them
- Beer on tap and what styles they are
- Wines by the glass and what they pair with
- Non-alcoholic options and mocktails

Try this: Make menu flashcards. Put the dish name on one side and ingredients, allergens, and your go-to description on the other. Study five a day.

For upselling scripts and more sales techniques, see Guide 01 in this series.

CHAPTER 6

Food Safety and Allergy Awareness

Allergy awareness is non-negotiable

Food allergies can be life-threatening. In the U.S., the major food allergens are:

Major allergen	Common sources on menus
Milk	Butter, cheese, cream sauces, some breads
Eggs	Aioli, mayonnaise, batters, pasta, baked goods
Fish	Fish sauce, Caesar dressing, Worcestershire
Shellfish	Shrimp, crab, lobster, some stocks
Tree nuts	Pesto, desserts, some sauces and oils
Peanuts	Sauces, dressings, desserts, fryer oils
Wheat	Breads, batters, pasta, soy sauce, thickened sauces
Soy	Soy sauce, tofu, many processed ingredients
Sesame	Buns, dressings, tahini, hummus

The allergy protocol

1. **Ask** every table if anyone has allergies.
2. **Listen** carefully and write it down.
3. **Check** with the kitchen or manager. Never guess about ingredients.
4. **Communicate** the allergy clearly on the ticket and in person, following restaurant policy.
5. **Deliver** allergy meals separately if you can, confirming with the guest.

Important: Never tell a guest a dish is "safe" if you aren't completely sure. "Let me check with the kitchen" is always the right answer.

Basic food safety for FOH

- Wash your hands often, especially after clearing plates, handling cash, or touching your face or phone.
- Hold plates by the edges and glasses by the stem or base, never by the rim.

- Don't touch ice or ready-to-eat food with bare hands; use scoops and tongs.
- Report spills immediately and clean them up to prevent slips.

CHAPTER 7

Responsible Alcohol Service

If you serve alcohol, you're responsible for serving it legally and safely.

- **Check ID** for anyone who looks under the age your restaurant's policy sets (often 30 or 40). Know what a valid ID looks like in your state.
- **Watch for signs of intoxication:** slurred speech, loud or aggressive behavior, stumbling, spilling drinks.
- **Slow down service** by offering water and food, and taking longer between rounds.
- **Involve a manager** before cutting someone off, and do it privately and respectfully.
- **Never serve** a visibly intoxicated guest or a minor.

Many states require or encourage alcohol server training such as ServSafe Alcohol or TIPS. It's a valuable certification even if your state doesn't require it.

CHAPTER 8

Handling Difficult Situations

Difficult guests

Use the **HEARD** method:

- **Hear** the guest out fully without interrupting.
- **Empathize**: "I understand how frustrating that must be."
- **Apologize** sincerely, even if it isn't your fault.
- **Resolve** the issue quickly, or get a manager.
- **Diagnose** afterwards: what caused it, and how can you prevent it next time?

When to get a manager right away

- A guest is aggressive, threatening, or harassing you or others
- There's a food allergy reaction or medical emergency
- A guest wants something only a manager can approve (large comps, policy exceptions)
- A guest is visibly intoxicated or a minor is trying to order alcohol
- You feel unsafe for any reason

Important: You never have to tolerate harassment or threats from guests. Tell a manager. If you're being mistreated by management, see Guide 03.

Staying calm under pressure

- **Breathe**: a slow breath in for 4 counts and out for 6 resets your nervous system in seconds.
- **Prioritize**: use the priority order from Guide 01 to decide what's next.
- **Ask for help early**, before you're drowning.
- **Take it one table at a time**. You can't fix the whole room at once.

CHAPTER 9

POS, Payments, and Cash Handling

- Enter orders and modifiers carefully. Double-check before you send.
- Never leave your server login open. Log out every time.
- Count your cash bank at the start and end of each shift.
- Present change and receipts accurately and politely.
- Follow your restaurant's rules for voids and comps. Always get approval.
- Keep your own record of tips and sales (see the tracker in Guide 01).

CHAPTER 10

Growing Your Career

FOH skills can lead to many roles:

Role	Skills to build
Host → Server	Menu knowledge, table management, sales
Server → Bartender	Drink knowledge, speed, multitasking
Server → Trainer	Communication, patience, service standards
Trainer → Shift lead / Supervisor	Leadership, conflict resolution, scheduling
Supervisor → Manager	Finances, hiring, operations, labor laws

Certifications that add value

- **Food handler card** (required in many states and counties)
- **ServSafe Alcohol** or **TIPS** (responsible alcohol service)
- **ServSafe Food Protection Manager** (for supervisory roles)
- **Wine and spirits courses** (such as WSET Level 1 or introductory sommelier courses)

TOOLKIT

Worksheet: Skills Self-Assessment

Rate yourself honestly from 1 (need a lot of work) to 5 (I could train others on this).

Skill	Rating (1 to 5)	One thing I can practice this month
Hospitality mindset		
Communication		
Menu knowledge		
Multitasking and prioritizing		
Time management		
Memory and attention to detail		
Teamwork		
Problem-solving		
Staying calm under pressure		
Food safety and allergy awareness		
Responsible alcohol service		
POS and cash handling		

TOOLKIT

Worksheet: My Growth Plan

My top 3 strengths:

The 3 skills I want to improve most:

Certifications I want to earn (and by when):

The role I want in 1 year:

What I'll ask my manager to help me get there:

My first step this week:

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